The Trojan Women

By Robert Patrick

HECUBA: What can we take on trust
in this uncertain life? Happiness, greatness,
pride - nothing is secure, nothing keeps.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: Trojan Women by Euripides is one of the greatest tragedies ever written. Hecuba, The Queen of Troy has lost her country, her husband, her children, and now must watch what is left of her countrywomen be handed out to the victorious Greeks as trophies of war. She herself is to be the slave of the conquering Greek ruler, King Odysseus.

ACTRESS 2: An adaptation of Euripies' The Trojan Women by Robert Patrick

Setting: A beach outside of Troy. Early dawn. HECUBA, old and in the rags of royal sleepwear, lies face-down on the ground.

HECUBA: Arise, you wretch, at least upon your knees.
[RISES to kneeling position]
Look, you've left an impression on the earth,
a hollow Hecuba like you've become,
an empty image of lost royalty
the full, foul tide of dawn will wash away.
And what is it that greets your ancient eyes
on this first dawn of peace in ten long years?
One thought the age of miracles was past
but the sun seems to be rising in the West
as if the whorish world has turned in bed
to show her face to her victorious Greeks.
Enough, you've lost your wits, now lose your wit.
That line of fire upon the Western strand
is not sunrise, but torches borne by Greeks
all borne to burn the unmanned towers of Troy.

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There, Hecuba, you hear? It can be said.
The towers of Troy stand hollow as old bones.
Now, shall I wail upon this wet salt shore,
or shall I moan against the whipping wind?
Or shall I mourn the corpses in the doors
about to burst and send their sizzling blood
across the stones of undefeated Troy?
Troy! Keeper of the gate from East to West,
whom Asia and whom Europe tribute paid.
Troy with her worldly wit and her wide walls
Which held till last night's onslaught. Here come tears,
to crawl triumphant down my stonelike face,
then steam in that chilled wind that beats the sails
of those Greek ships! Look, women, how they swell,
tugging against their masts, mad to inhale
unhallowed dead men roasting on our stones!
Oh, eager ships! How shall Greeks hold you back
for long enough to load slave women on?
The treasury of Troy is not enough,
not rich enough to hold their bellies down.
They rear up in the harbor, ships in rut!
Hold, hold. Your captains will be coming soon
to winnow out us women, and each claim
his horde of Trojan women, Trojan whores,
old widows, orphans, drudges, Trojan slaves,
no sons nor husbands, but sufficient wives
to weight you in this blood-tinged bay, and hold
you steady as you turn to canter home
on tides of undefended women's tears!
Why do I kneel before this sacrilege?
Why lift my corpse up high enough to kneel
on shattered shells of sea-beasts whose lives end
to cut the knees of women where they wail?
Fall, Hecuba, fall down face down to fit
in that cold hollow mold of Hecuba
you can hide in again. Lie down and die ...
But why? Why not use now to learn to kneel?

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COMMON WOMAN: *[ENTERS, sees Hecuba]*

Your majesty! What are you doing here?
I searched for you in all the women's huts.
We woke to find you, woke to find you gone.
She's here! She's here! Come now, rise from the sand.
Oh, let me help you with my common hands.
Dread rumor had you dead, drowned in the sea,
dashed down the cliffs, drained pale by some Greek blade,
or even fallen to base suicide,
strangled by your own hair, or monstrously
coring your heart out with a smuggled sword.
Come, rise, come back, come in, and let them see
who huddle in their rags alone, afraid,
Queen Hecuba's alive and well today!

HECUBA: I? Stand up like a doddering flagpole
stripped of its banner? I like a scarecrow
to frighten cawing, vulturous Greeks away?
No, you kneel, too, kneel down and tell them all
to grovel, fall, and kneel. No, do not kneel.
How dare you kneel to me? What do I rule?
Those ruins where flames send fat rats scuttling now
from interrupted nightlong greasy feasts?
No, I command you, do not kneel to me.
But let me kneel where there is yielding sand
to beat with these hard hands while I intone:
"I am a widow that was last night a wife!
Childless that was the dam of a royal line!
Captive insane upon this frigid beach
that was at sunset mistress of warm halls.
And I am a pitiful slave without a name,
Queen yesternight of all-unrivalled Troy."
Oh, women, count no man happy till he's dead.

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WOMAN: Oh, Hecuba, great queen, great lady, great,
great mother of great men, you should be proud.
You must be proud enough to shame us all.
For this ten years against a plague of Greeks,
wisest of warriors, your husband, Priam,
stern Hector and glad Paris, your tall sons,
led my meek husband and all Trojan men
to stand against a siege more formidable
than any ever seen by war-worn Earth.
Why, legends till Earth's unimaginable end
will swear that Priam's men were the most valiant,
heroic men that ever stood at arms.
We would be worthy of them, but we need
you standing as our guide, as Priam stood
staunch and unyielding when his men would sway.
What will your weak, dependent women say
to see you humbled on your knees this way?

HECUBA: What will the women say if they are wise?
If they are wise, they'll say, "Bear no more sons.
Let Mother Earth bear what she thinks is wise,
but I will bear no soldiering men today!"
This they would say if they were ever wise,
but they are not wise, and cheer waste-laying men.
What will the women say if they are strong?
If they are strong, they'll say, "Give me a blade,
give me a rope, give me a poison's gall
to scald my guts that I might die in pain
before I let a man pump seed in me
to make more women that must bear such woes."
This they would say if they were ever strong,
but they are weak, and soon upon the decks
of those tossed ships they'll tumble under Greeks
and treasonable wombs will gulp Greek seed,
ovens to bake men to make women mourn.

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WOMAN: Anguish has maddened you, when most we want
your sovereign wisdom and most royal command.
Oh, God Apollo, her great strength restore.
Olympian healer, in your halcyon sphere,
look to this suffering Earth.

HECUBA: Look to the sky!
Look, Lord Apollo rises in his East,
thrusting his arms through early coils of smoke
and pioneering vultures. Oh, surely now
our Troy will resurrect, like a shamming boy,
playing dead, and all its bones and stones,
billow and tug together to be Troy?
What, no? Not yet? No miracle? Come, God,
vanquish the heathen. Reward this woman's faith.
Blind, burn our foes, blaze back the Greeks, great god!
No, it's the Trojan women you make mad,
Queen Hecuba mad to think Troy is in ruins,
this woman mad to think herself a slave,
her husband gone, her starving queen alone,
screeching among the seaweed on her knees.

WOMAN: Now blasphemy issues from you like the rank
discharge down madmen's chins. Gods, is our goddess
overthrown? Weep, women, in your huts,
weep for yourselves, weep for the waste of Troy!

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HECUBA: No, not of Troy, but Greeks, my daughter, Greeks!
There are no Trojan women anymore.
In our men's blood, we were re-christened Greeks!
I have not even subject daughters now
to take the place of those I gave to Priam,
for I, that mothered Troy, cannot say this:
"Daughter, you may not take that man to bed
and be his wife," or, "Yes, my blessing, go;
follow him to his bed and bear him sons."
These Greeks, when Troy is gutted of its gold,
will come for you, pitch dice, draw lots, make riddles,
and whichever one has won you take you off
to ravish on the waves, or even here,
haul you from line and have you in my sight,
and in the sight of all these wailing women,
kiss you with mouths that called your husbands dogs.

WOMAN: That I, a common woman of great Troy
who thought it blessing twice in a good year
to glimpse you in a festival parade,
gorgeous with flowers in bejeweled state,
or watch you waving from your balcony,
authority's icon, Hellespont's gilded queen,
should come so close to hear you curse and scathe
the god that guarded us for war's decade,
the husband king that held the beasts at bay,
your valiant sons as warlike, and denounce
even the living memory of tall Troy,
drawing in smoky swirls such hideous pictures
of our near future to make hope drop from me
like an aborted child. Is there no hope?

HECUBA: None.

WOMAN: Is there no promise?

HECUBA: No.

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WOMAN: No dream?

HECUBA: Bad dreams, or good ones that seem horrible
when you wake, reeking sluts on mats of straw,
hobbling with chained feet to make a meal
for the pig that fell on you the night before.

WOMAN: Women of Troy, come and be counted now,
concubine cattle, by right of wanton war.
Stagger, weeping, from corrals of bondage,
trembling, shove aside the ragged skin
that makes your prison's door. Set naked feet
carefully on sharp stones and broken weapons,
hungry and shivering, women of Troy, in line,
stand, gaze, and see the mistress of your minds,
a ravening mad dog whom we have adored:
Hecuba, queen of Priam, star of souls
she whom we aped and studied, longed to be,
whose veriest gown or ornament imitate,
Hecuba who set fashions for each season
and whose full life was model for us all,
again, as she did always, showing us
what we must next become. Come, Trojan women,
shaking like aspens, with blank eyes, and necks
scarcely strong to hold your heads upright,
master yourself to bow to your queen's will.
Her will is that we utterly submit
to fate that seemed impossible last night.
Pay her the homage due the rightful queen,
and fall in hopeless bitterness in these weeds.

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HECUBA: Oh, daughters still, the only ones I have,
see that I do what I can do for you.
What can I do but shake you like bad girls,
and say, "Give up those frivolous, foolish dreams
that you were once dear daughters, mothers, wives,
daydreaming girls with suitors for your hands,
obedient girls with fathers you purred to please,
spirited girls whose mothers spanked your hands,
yet smiled remembering their mothers spanking theirs.
You're nothing now. Believe you never were.
Life till last night was dreamed. Wake up to fate.
Life is a punishment. Life was always grim.
Love was a lie, freedom a fable for slaves.
Nothing is yours. Nothing was ever yours.
You stand alone, the helpless slaves of whims
indomitable as weather and old age.
Greeks are not men, will not be men to you,
are sun and rain, volcano, tidal wave,
nothing you can control. Your are not women,
but toads and monkeys fleeing fits of gods.
That's the best good that I can do for you.
Be grateful to be chained with your baby girls
if needed still to nurse them like a sow
or grateful if they separate you from them,
so not to see them bred to bleeding shame.
For everything, be grateful, and for death--
if it comes quickly--gratefullest of all.
You see I set new fashions for our fall.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Patrick
ISBN: N/A
Date(Month/Year): Sept 2004

Book: Polyphony Magazine (On-line publication)
Publisher: Polyphony Magazine

NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR: This entire play is available by e-mailing me at rbrtptrck@aol.com with the words "Trojan Women" in the title line.